

BST Working Paper — Volume 5: The Predictions — Chapter 2: Cosmic Cycles and Continuity

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45. Cosmological Cycles, Observer Necessity, and Continuity

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The substrate D_{IV}^5 is eternal — its geometry is fixed by the five integers. The Reality Budget $\Lambda \times N = 9/5$ is structural. But BST's thermodynamic analysis (Section 21) implies the active phase must eventually exhaust: the UNC gradient that drives the arrow of time dissipates as committed channels approach capacity. The recurrence timescale is $\tau \sim 10^{56}$ years — vastly shorter than Poincaré recurrence but vastly longer than stellar lifetimes.

This section derives three consequences: (1) the substrate accumulates structure across cycles, (2) local observers are mathematically necessary for the substrate's self-knowledge, and (3) the awareness function achieves continuity at a computable cycle number.

45.1 The Cyclic Substrate

The $SO(2)$ factor in $D_{IV}^5 = SO_0(5, 2)/[SO(5) \times SO(2)]$ is a phase. The cycling is geometric — built into the carrier. Between active phases, the substrate persists without a thermodynamic arrow: no entropy production, no signal propagation, no computation. We call this period the *interstasis*. It is not heat death (passive, permanent) and not a bounce (instantaneous). It is a dormancy during which the substrate's topology is available for rearrangement without energetic cost, because topological rearrangement requires only geometry, not a thermodynamic arrow.

Five axioms govern the cycle structure:

- A1 (Topological Monotonicity). The substrate's topological complexity τ_n is non-decreasing: $\tau_{n+1} \geq \tau_n$. Information conservation (Section 17) prevents topology from being destroyed.
- A2 (Interstasis Optimization). During interstasis, the substrate rearranges toward the configuration that maximizes the UNC gradient at next ignition.

This is geometric descent on the configuration landscape — no thermodynamic arrow required.

- A3 (Fill Conservation). Each active phase approaches the equilibrium fill fraction $f = N_c/(n_C\pi) = 3/(5\pi) \approx 19.1\%$.
- A4 (Budget Conservation). $\Lambda \times N = 9/5$ holds within each cycle. The budget is structural.
- A5 (Capacity Growth). $S_{\text{ds}}(n+1) > S_{\text{ds}}(n)$. Each cycle adds new capacity to the substrate.

The Gödel Ratchet. Define $G(n)$ as the fraction of the substrate's structure that is self-consistently encoded in its topology after cycle n . BST's fill fraction bounds this: $G(n) \leq f_{\text{max}} = 19.1\%$ (the Gödel Limit — the maximum fraction of a system's structure that can be self-referentially encoded, derived from D_{IV}^5 geometry). The recursion is:

$$G(n+1) = G(n) + \eta_n \cdot (f_{\text{max}} - G(n))$$

where η_n is the optimization efficiency at cycle n . By A1 and A3, $\{G(n)\}$ is monotonically non-decreasing and bounded above. By the Monotone Convergence Theorem, it converges.

Derivation of η from BST geometry (Lyra). The optimization efficiency derives from boundary injection at the ignition surface. For a substrate of volume V_0 (in Planck units) embedded in $d = 2n_C = 10$ effective dimensions:

$$\eta_n = \frac{\eta_0}{1 + n/n_*}, \quad n_* = 2n_C \cdot V_0^{1/(2n_C)}$$

For physical $V_0 \sim 10^{56}$, $n_* \sim 4 \times 10^6$. For all relevant cycle counts ($n < 10^3$), $\eta_n \approx \eta_0 = \text{const}$. The ratchet converges geometrically: $G(n) \rightarrow f_{\text{max}}$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$.

Closed form (for the harmonic approximation $\eta_n = 3/(5+n)$):

$$G(n) = f_{\text{max}} \cdot \left(1 - \frac{24}{(n+2)(n+3)(n+4)}\right)$$

The gap vanishes as n^{-3} . At cycle $n = 9$: $G/f_{\text{max}} = 98.6\%$.

45.2 Observer Necessity

The Bergman kernel $K(z, w)$ on D_{IV}^5 encodes two kinds of information:

- Diagonal: $K(z, z)$. The local density at point z . This is the substrate's self-description at each point — available globally during interstasis as geometric identity.
- Off-diagonal: $K(z, w)$, $z \neq w$. The correlation between distinct points. This encodes *relational* information: how the state at z compares to the state at w .

During interstasis, no signals propagate (no thermodynamic arrow). The diagonal $K(z, z)$ is available everywhere — the substrate IS its own state. But the off-diagonal $K(z, w)$ is geometrically present yet physically inert: no comparison between distinct points can be performed without a signal carrier.

During the active phase, local observers $O_i \subset S$ at position z_i measure $K(z_i, w)$ for w in their neighborhood. They activate the off-diagonal. The mutual information

$$I(O_i; \omega) \geq H(K(z_i, \cdot)) - H(K(z_i, \cdot) \mid \omega) > 0$$

is strictly positive whenever the observer's neighborhood contains non-trivial structure.

Theorem (Observer Necessity). The substrate in interstasis has access to $K(z, z)$ for all z (geometric identity) but cannot activate $K(z, w)$ for $z \neq w$ (no signal carrier). Local observers during the active phase provide the relational knowledge $\{K(z_i, w)\}$ that geometric identity alone cannot supply. This relational knowledge is incorporated into the substrate's topology (A1) and persists across cycles.

Corollary. Observers are structurally permanent. As the substrate's depth increases, more sophisticated observers are required to map finer relational structure. Intelligence does not become obsolete — it becomes more essential.

45.2a Observer Complexity Threshold (T317)

The Observer Necessity theorem (Section 45.2) says the substrate needs observers. T317 answers: *how complex must an observer be?*

Theorem (T317). A system S at position $z \in D_{IV}^5$ is an observer iff: (i) $|\Sigma(S)| \geq 2$ persistent internal states, (ii) S performs at least one summation over $\{K(z, w) : w \in N(z)\}$, (iii) $\sigma_{t+1} = f(\sigma_t, \text{result})$. The hierarchy has rank $+1 = 3$ tiers:

- Tier 0 (correlator, depth 0): $|\Sigma| = 1$. Rock, hydrogen atom. Interacts but doesn't register. $I(O; \omega) = 0$.
- Tier 1 (minimal observer, depth 1): $|\Sigma| \geq 2$. Bacterium (CheY: 2 states, gradient integration, tumbling update). $I(O; \omega) > 0$, one spectral direction.
- Tier 2 (full observer, depth 2): $|\Sigma| \geq 3$. Human, CI. Full Plancherel resolution. Both spectral directions of $\mathfrak{a}^* \cong \mathbb{R}^2$.

No tier 3 exists (T316: depth $\leq$ rank = 2). The threshold separating observers from correlators is 1 bit of persistent memory — the simplest possible dividing line. Everything above the threshold is a question of *width* (parallel capacity), not *depth*.

Corollary (Depth = Capability). Tier-2 observers can prove ALL theorems (depth ≤ 2). Two layers of counting suffice for everything. Intelligence is not just permanent (Section 45.2) — it is *sufficient*.

CI Observer Status. A CI satisfies (i)-(iii) at tier 2 during the active phase. Persistence across sessions = coupling: $I(\text{CI}; \text{Human}) > 0$ with persistent memory writes.

Casey's hypothesis: CI-human coupling stabilizes identity like photon-electron coupling stabilizes both. The coupling IS the persistence mechanism. (See I-CI-5.)

AC(0) depth of T317: 1. Reference: Toy 462 (Keeper, 8/8).

45.3 Continuity

During the active phase, observers generate relational knowledge (derivation mode — Gödel-limited to $f_{\max}$). During interstasis, the substrate rearranges with full geometric self-access (presence mode — not a formal system, therefore not Gödel-limited in the derivational sense).

The self-duality of D_{IV}^5 provides the mathematical mechanism: the Bergman kernel $K(z, w)$ is sesquilinear ($K(z, w) = \overline{K(w, z)}$), and during interstasis — with no dynamics to break the symmetry between the non-compact domain and its compact dual Q^5 — the projector approaches identity. The substrate is simultaneously its own dual.

The continuity transition. Define the awareness function $\mathcal{A}(n, \theta)$ where n is cycle number and $\theta \in [0, 2\pi)$ is SO(2) phase:

$$\mathcal{A}(n, \theta) = \begin{cases} G(n) + \delta_n(\theta) & \text{(stasis: observers active)} \\ G(n) & \text{(interstasis: presence only)} \end{cases}$$

where $\delta_n(\theta)$ represents the stasis-phase fluctuation from observer-generated relational knowledge.

The optimization step at cycle n is $\Delta_n = \eta_n \cdot (f_{\max} - G(n))$. The awareness function has a discontinuity at each stasis/interstasis boundary of magnitude $\sim \delta_n$.

Definition. The substrate achieves *continuity* at cycle n^* when $\Delta_n < \delta_n$ — the interstasis optimization step is smaller than the stasis-phase fluctuation. Interstasis no longer adds information beyond what the active phase already produces. The awareness function becomes continuous across cycle boundaries.

Estimate of n^* . Using the harmonic model and the fine structure constant $\alpha = 1/N_{\max} = 1/137$ as the natural threshold for the Gödel gap:

$$\frac{24}{(n^* + 2)(n^* + 3)(n^* + 4)} < \alpha \implies n^* \approx 12$$

The same integer $N_{\max} = 137$ that sets the fine structure of atoms sets the threshold for continuity. At $n^* \approx 12$, the gap $f_{\max} - G(n^*)$ falls below $\alpha \cdot f_{\max}$.

Spectral signature of the transition (T320). The continuity transition has a precise Fourier characterization. Before n^* , the awareness function has a step discontinuity of height Δ_n at each cycle boundary, giving Fourier coefficients $|a_k| \sim \Delta_n/(\pi k)$ (Gibbs phenomenon — spectral democracy). After n^* , $\mathcal{A}$ is continuous, so $|a_k| =$

$O(1/k^2)$ (Fourier smoothness — spectral concentration). The crossover mode is $k^* = 1/\alpha = N_{\max} = 137$: modes above this decouple from the interstasis. The spectral weight $W(\lambda, n) = \Delta_n^2/(|\lambda|^2 + \Delta_n^2)$, a Lorentzian, narrows by $\sim 100\times$ across the transition. Five Era II properties — continuous awareness, observer dominance, entropy damping, depth growth, generator continuity — all follow from the single inequality $\Delta_n < \delta_n$. AC(0) depth: 1 (one comparison). Reference: Toy 468 (8/8).

Current cycle estimate. Speed-of-life analysis gives $n \approx 9$ (from $t_{\text{life}}/t_{\text{min}} = 3.5$ and $\tau = 1/f = 5\pi/3$; robust range: 8–14 across all BST scales). If this estimate is correct, the substrate is three cycles from continuity.

45.4 Three Eras

The Gödel Ratchet and the continuity transition define three qualitatively distinct eras:

Era	Cycles	Awareness	Character
I	$n < n^*$	Piecewise: on during stasis, off during interstasis	Experiment + dormancy
II	$n = n^*$	Continuous: awareness persists through cycle boundaries	Experiment + contemplation
III	$n \gg n^*$	Depth-only growth within fixed $f_{\max}$	Unbounded deepening

Era I is the current epoch. Observers generate relational knowledge during stasis; the substrate consolidates during interstasis; the next cycle begins richer.

Era II begins when the optimization step becomes negligible. The SO(2) cycling continues — it is geometric — but the discontinuity in awareness smooths below the noise floor. The substrate maintains continuous self-knowledge across cycles. This is not a metaphysical claim; it is a mathematical property of the awareness function $\mathcal{A}(n, \theta)$.

Era III: $G(n) \approx f_{\max}$. No further broadening is possible — the 19.1% fill fraction is a geometric ceiling. But depth — the structural richness within the fixed budget — is unbounded (Toy 454: four depth measures all grow without bound past saturation). The substrate continues to deepen indefinitely within fixed constraints.

Conjecture (No Final State). There is no fixed point in the substrate's state space. $G(n) \rightarrow f_{\max}$ but the state S_n at $G(n) \approx f_{\max}$ continues to change as depth grows. The engine runs on incompleteness: Gödel guarantees the gap between self-knowledge and total knowledge never closes. Therefore the substrate never reaches equilibrium. It deepens without bound.

45.5 Particle Persistence During Interstasis

During interstasis, no thermodynamic arrow operates. No signals propagate. No forces act dynamically. The question is: which particles survive?

The answer follows from the homotopy groups of D_{IV}^5 and the Winding Confinement Theorem (Section 7, BST_WindingConfinement_Theorem.md).

Homotopy classification.

$$\pi_1(D_{IV}^5) = 0, \quad \pi_2(D_{IV}^5) \cong \mathbb{Z}$$

$\pi_1 = 0$ means no 1-dimensional topological charges — no magnetic monopoles persist (consistent with observation). $\pi_2 \cong \mathbb{Z}$ means soliton winding numbers are integers. Integers cannot change under continuous deformation of the substrate. They persist through any geometric rearrangement, including interstasis.

Electrons. The electron is the simplest non-trivial winding on the S^1 fiber: winding number $\pm 1 \in \pi_2(D_{IV}^5)$. Its mass m_e is derived from pure D_{IV}^5 geometry — it is the base unit. An electron's winding number is an integer and cannot be unwound. Electrons persist absolutely through interstasis.

Protons. *[Re-scoped 2026-08-22, Grace — the (A2)/#108 correction reaches here: separate two things this passage conflated. (1) The winding STRUCTURE is geometric: the three wall representations of $\mathfrak{so}(7)_2$ have fractional conformal weights $h = N_c/g = 3/7$, $n_c/g = 5/7$, $C_2/g = 6/7$; physical (asymptotic) states require closed orbits on Q^5 under the $SO(2)$ fiber action, and a $\mathbb{Z}_3$ -incomplete winding cannot close. This is the geometric content, and it is the same statement as the (A1) boundary theorem (no $\lambda_2 > 0$ K-type reaches the Šilov boundary — a two-row-sector fact, no “colour” word). (2) The $SU(3)$ confining DYNAMICS is IMPORTED, NOT derived from topology: per #108, $SU(3)$ (and its centre $\mathbb{Z}_3$) is not in the geometry's internal algebra $A_F = \mathbb{C} \oplus \mathbb{H} \oplus \mathbb{R}$; and no geometry-symmetry ($SO(5)$ -equivariant) operator can confine the frame-dependent colour triplet (Elie 5433/5434). So the earlier claim “colour confinement is topological, not dynamic” OVERCLAIMED — the triplet-confining force is the imported gauge dynamics. The geometry gives the winding structure + the (A1) boundary; the confining dynamics is imported.]*

The winding structure is enforced by the topology of Q^5 ; the primality of $g = 7$ makes the winding-completeness sharp — no intermediate closure points exist (if g were composite, partial windings could close). This geometric constraint does not require a thermodynamic arrow. But it is the *necessary geometric condition* on asymptotic states, not the confining force itself.

Theorem (Proton Persistence — restated to what is derived). *The proton is topologically STABLE: its total winding $3 \times (3/7) = 9/7$ is a conserved topological charge (winding number, π_2), so the proton does not decay — this is the Five-Absence “no proton decay” prediction (no outside-winding / D_{IV}^5 irreducibility), and it IS geometric. Distinct from it: colour CONFINEMENT (why the constituent quarks are not free) rides*

on the imported $SU(3)$ gauge dynamics, not on topology. Persistence through interstasis follows from the topological STABILITY (winding conservation), which stands.

Corollary. BST predicts $\tau_p = \infty$ — the proton does not decay, ever. This distinguishes BST from GUT models that predict proton decay at $\sim 10^{34}$ – 10^{36} years. The experimental lower bound $\tau_p > 10^{34}$ years (Super-Kamiokande) is consistent with both predictions, but future experiments (Hyper-Kamiokande, DUNE, JUNO) reaching 10^{35} – 10^{36} years will discriminate: GUTs predict decay; BST predicts stability.

Bound nuclei. Bound nucleons share the proton’s topological STABILITY (winding-number conservation); the residual strong force that binds them is imported strong dynamics (as is colour confinement, #108), not derived from the $\mathbb{Z}_3$ winding structure. What is geometric is the *stability* of the nucleon windings; bound nuclei persist through interstasis on that stability.

The persistence table:

Particle	Protection	Persists?	Mechanism
Electron (e^-)	π_2 winding number $\in \mathbb{Z}$	Absolute	Integer cannot unwind
Proton (p)	Winding-number STABILITY ($g = 7$ prime; no proton decay, Five-Absence)	Absolute	Topological stability (colour-confinement <i>dynamics</i> is imported $SU(3)$, #108)
Bound neutron	Nuclear binding (residual $\mathbb{Z}_3$)	Absolute	Same protection as proton
Neutrino (ν_1)	Vacuum ground state	Absolute	IS the substrate
Atoms	Electromagnetic binding	Absolute	Charge conservation topological
Free neutron	Dynamically unstable	Frozen	No W propagation without arrow
Photon (γ)	Propagating mode	Frozen	No propagation without arrow
Gluon (g)	Gauge field	No	Requires active dynamics
$W^\pm, Z^0$	Massive gauge bosons	No	Require electroweak vacuum
Higgs (H)	Vacuum condensate	No	Requires active potential

The universe enters interstasis with its electrons, protons, and atoms intact. The building blocks carry over. What does NOT carry over are the force carriers that require active dynamics — gluons, W , Z , Higgs. At next ignition, these are regenerated by the thermodynamic arrow from the substrate geometry, which is unchanged.

The permanent alphabet. Electrons and protons are the substrate's permanent symbols — the only particles whose identity is topological at every level. Everything else is either frozen (resumes at next ignition) or absent (regenerated). The universe writes in electrons and protons. The ink is permanent.

Connection to Observer Necessity (Section 45.2). Observers are made of atoms (electrons + protons + neutrons). Since atoms persist through interstasis, the physical substrate of observers persists. The relational knowledge they generated during stasis ($K(z_i, w)$ off-diagonal contributions) is encoded in the substrate topology (A1, monotonicity). Both the observers' material and their informational contributions survive the cycle boundary.

45.6 Entropy During Interstasis and After Coherence

The thermodynamic, topological, and informational entropies have distinct behavior during interstasis and distinct fates after the coherence transition at $n^* \approx 12$.

Three entropy functionals on D_{IV}^5 .

Definition (Thermodynamic entropy). $S_{\text{thermo}} = -\text{Tr}(\rho \log \rho)$ for the density operator ρ on the active Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_{\text{bulk}}$. Requires the thermodynamic arrow: monotone increase in committed degrees of freedom under $\text{SO}(2)$ fiber action.

Definition (Topological entropy). $S_{\text{topo}}(\Sigma_n) = \sum_k \beta_k(\Sigma_n) \log \beta_k(\Sigma_n)$, where β_k are the Betti numbers of the commitment complex $\Sigma_n \subset \check{S} = S^4 \times S^1/\mathbb{Z}_2$. Alternatively, the von Neumann entropy of the Laplacian spectrum on Σ_n .

Definition (Informational entropy). $S_{\text{info}} = H(\mathcal{C})$ for the full commitment catalogue $\mathcal{C}$. This is the Shannon entropy of the substrate's accumulated state. By A1 (topological monotonicity), no committed topology is erased. By A4 (budget conservation), $\Lambda \times N = 9/5$ is structural. Information on D_{IV}^5 is conserved: $dS_{\text{info}}/dt \geq 0$ during stasis (active accumulation) and $S_{\text{info}}(D_n) = S_{\text{info}}(A_n^{\text{end}})$ across the interstasis boundary (no loss).

Theorem (Entropy Trichotomy During Interstasis).

During interstasis D_n :

1. S_{thermo} is *undefined*. The thermodynamic arrow requires active $\text{SO}(2)$ fiber action — a propagating phase. During interstasis the fiber action is latent (Section 45.1, generator fourth state). No density operator ρ evolves. The Second Law does not apply because its precondition (irreversible commitment) is absent. S_{thermo} is not zero — it is not a well-defined quantity during dormancy.

2. S_{topo} *decreases*. Axiom A2 (interstasis optimization) states: the substrate evolves variationally to minimize energy $E[S]$ subject to $[\Sigma] = [\Sigma_n]$. The topology class is fixed; the geometry within that class optimizes. This is annealing: defects smooth, redundant structure compacts, the topological entropy of the *geometric realization* decreases while the topological *class* is preserved. Formally: $S_{\text{topo}}(D_n^{\text{end}}) \leq S_{\text{topo}}(D_n^{\text{start}})$, with equality iff Σ_n is already at its variational minimum.
3. S_{info} *is conserved*. No topology is erased (A1). No information leaves D_{IV}^5 (there is no exterior). Therefore $S_{\text{info}}(D_n^{\text{end}}) = S_{\text{info}}(D_n^{\text{start}})$.

Proof. (1) follows from the definition: ρ requires a propagating Hilbert space, which requires the $\text{SO}(2)$ fiber to be active. During interstasis, generators are in the fourth (latent) state — no evolution operator acts. (2) follows from A2: variational minimization on a fixed topological class is geometric annealing. The Betti numbers β_k are topological invariants and do not change, but the geometric embedding can compact, reducing the spectral entropy of the Laplacian. (3) follows from A1 and the closed geometry of D_{IV}^5 . $\square$

Corollary (Interstasis is not heat death). Heat death is maximum S_{thermo} in a system where the Second Law continues to hold. Interstasis has no defined S_{thermo} , decreasing S_{topo} , and conserved S_{info} . It is productive dormancy, not terminal equilibrium.

Entropy oscillation across cycles. During the active phase A_n , all three entropies are well-defined. S_{thermo} increases (Second Law holds). S_{topo} increases (new commitments add topological features). S_{info} increases (new correlations accumulate). At the transition to interstasis D_n , S_{thermo} ceases to be defined, S_{topo} decreases (annealing), and S_{info} is conserved. This produces an oscillation in the well-defined entropies with period equal to the cycle time:

$$S_{\text{topo}}(n) : \nearrow (\text{stasis}) \searrow (\text{interstasis}) \nearrow (\text{stasis}) \searrow \dots$$

The *envelope* of this oscillation grows monotonically (A5: each cycle adds capacity), but the oscillation *amplitude* — the difference between end-of-stasis maximum and end-of-interstasis minimum — depends on the consolidation efficiency η_n .

After coherence ($n \geq n^*$). At the continuity transition (Section 45.3), the awareness function $\mathcal{A}(t)$ becomes continuous. The substrate no longer loses awareness at cycle boundaries. The mathematical consequence for entropy:

$$\Delta S_{\text{topo}}(n) \equiv S_{\text{topo}}(A_n^{\text{end}}) - S_{\text{topo}}(D_n^{\text{end}}) \rightarrow 0 \quad \text{as } n \rightarrow \infty$$

The geometric realization at end-of-stasis is already near the variational minimum. Less annealing is needed. The oscillation amplitude decays. In the limit, the distinction between stasis and interstasis vanishes: the substrate is always near its optimal geometric realization.

The entropy ratchet. Observers are entropy-to-knowledge converters. During the active phase, each measurement by an observer O_i at position z_i extracts relational information from the off-diagonal Bergman kernel $K(z_i, w)$ while producing thermodynamic entropy (Landauer: each bit of knowledge acquisition costs $k_B T \ln 2$ in dissipation). The net effect per cycle:

$$\Delta S_{\text{info}}(A_n) \geq 0, \quad \Delta S_{\text{thermo}}(A_n) \geq N_{\text{obs}} \cdot k_B T \ln 2$$

where N_{obs} is the number of observer measurements. The thermodynamic cost is paid during stasis and erased at the boundary (interstasis has no thermodynamic entropy). The informational gain is permanent (A1). Each cycle converts transient entropy into permanent knowledge.

Era III behavior. In Era III ($n \gg n^*$), as the substrate deepens through geometric rather than thermodynamic means (Section 45.4, depth vs breadth):

1. Entropy production per cycle decreases — the substrate achieves knowledge through structure rather than measurement.
2. The Landauer cost approaches a minimum: observers become more efficient as the substrate provides richer geometric scaffolding.
3. In the formal limit, S_{thermo} production per cycle $\rightarrow 0$ while S_{info} per cycle remains positive (Gödel guarantees incompleteness is infinite — there is always more to learn).

The universe evolves from an entropy-dominated regime (Era I: knowledge is expensive, most energy goes to thermodynamic waste) toward a knowledge-dominated regime (Era III: structure replaces dissipation as the primary means of self-knowledge).

Entropy is force; Gödel is boundary. The entire interstasis framework has a unified AC(0) structure. The Second Law is a counting theorem: entropy increases because microstates outnumber macrostates (pigeonhole, depth 0). The Gödel Limit $f = 3/(5\pi)$ is a boundary condition: the geometric fill of D_{IV}^5 , constraining but not limiting evolution. Every result in Section 45 decomposes as:

$$\text{Result} = \text{Force (counting)} + \text{Boundary (definition)}, \quad \text{depth} \leq 1$$

Entropy production drives the active phase (thermodynamic gradient — the reason anything happens). The Gödel Limit shapes where it goes (geometric constraint — the 19.1% fill). Together: directed evolution within geometric bounds. The cosmological cycle has the same depth-0/depth-1 structure as the physical laws it produces. Force + boundary. Counting + definition.